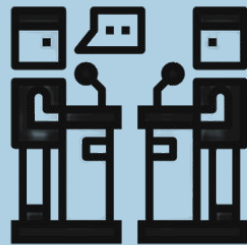


BURBANK DEBATE



**A LECTURE ON THE ART OF
CONGRESSIONAL REFUTATION**

BY SUNGJOO YOON



what am i gonna go over?

i'm gonna answer 5 core questions today.

- ❑ what are refutations - and what purpose do they serve?
- ❑ what are the in-round prereqs to refutations?
- ❑ what does an effective refutation look like?
- ❑ how do i perform one?
- ❑ what are the different strategies / styles to refutations?

and after these 5 questions are answered, you're gonna be an absolute ref jesus!

dw i'll also continuously answer questions throughout and @ the end as well.

what are refutations - and what purpose do they serve?

a refutation - at its core - is a response to an argument.

more importantly, their purpose in congressional debate is twofold.

- ❑ first, refutations add credibility to your persuasion. in a debate event where your ranks are based on how persuasive you are, they add 'ethos' to your speech.
- ❑ second, refutations attack the flow. the 'flow' is a logical sequence of every argument made in a given discussion. refutations are a tool to directly engage with this 'flow'.

let's go over both in detail! ->

what purpose do they serve? (part 1)

adding credibility to your persuasion.

that is to say, anyone can go up and give an oratory for 3 minutes. what esoterically sets apart good speakers from the best, and gives you major cred in the eyes of judges, is the **ability to successfully challenge & overturn a long-standing belief in a discussion** .

you sound much smarter, more convincing, and last longer in the minds of judges if you can successfully answer the concerns of the other side. and refutations allow you to steer the direction of the debate - being a dominant figure in the round and the cornerstone of discussion increases your round presence which = better ranks.

what purpose do they serve? (part 2)

refutations attack the flow.

the ‘flow’ is a logical sequence of every argument made in a given discussion. while this is a rather technical debate term, it matters to all judges because even if they don’t understand its technicality, anyone adjudicating a debate (and paying attention) will have at least some understanding of the logical progressions in thinking.

refutations provide you direct access onto the ‘flow’. say a speaker on the other side has made a really good argument; which judges will now listen to, think about, and understand. now, judges think that speaker has made a good argument and will rank them above you. if you refute them, and cut down their logic, judges now have a reason to vote against the initial argument and won’t think of them as highly.

what purpose do they serve? (part 2.5)

refutations attack the flow (con't)

for example, say there's an argument on whether dogs are better than cats.

aff speaker #1 says that dogs are better because they're cuter. ->

neg speaker #1 then refutes by giving a study that explains why cats are actually cuter, and gives empirics on why aff speaker #1's analysis is off.

this is a logical sequence of the argument on the 'cuteness' debate. while aff speaker #1 makes a solid point that a judge can vote / rank on, neg speaker #1 gives them a counter-reason not to do so, making aff speaker #1 less competitive by hurting their logical processions.

what purpose do they serve? (part 2.5 con't)

refutations attack the flow (con't)

Flowing an Argument in an Affirmative Constructive

Pro Case	Con Rebuttal	Pro Rebuttal	Con Summary	Pro Summary
1. Legalizing marijuana would decrease burden on prison system	<i>So would legalizing murder, but we don't do that</i>	Not the same thing; marijuana isn't violent crime	→	They acknowledge that marijuana is a nonviolent offense
a. Prisons are overcrowded NYTimes, 5/09 Prisons at 120% capacity	<i>Only applies to public prisons</i>	Still serious problem	<i>How serious? Private prisons actually more common</i>	They don't provide evidence for this
b. Drug crimes responsible for this Economist, 12/11 80% of felons in prison for drugs	<i>But some commit other crimes, too</i>	→	<i>They ignore this; it means that legalizing marijuana wouldn't really create much space in prisons b/c the criminals are there for other reasons</i>	
c. Legal marijuana would free up space for violent felons Some felons are released early b/c no space	<i>No evidence for this, how many are released?</i>	If any violent felons are released early, then that's unacceptable	→	If we prove that even one violent criminal is released early b/c of overcrowding, that means marijuana should be legalized to help our prison system do its job
d. Impact is less crime b/c fewer violent criminals released	→	They don't dispute the impact; reducing crime is good	<i>Reducing crime would be good, but the pro team doesn't do it</i>	

this is a quick example of a further logical procession and 'flow' in a debate. for every argument is a counterclaim, and for every counterclaim is a frontline response to that. these logical lines of understanding are the subconscious processes our brains undertake when we either debate or even judge debates.

the effect of persuasion on human beings stems from being able to understand these processions, and to draw conclusions on who makes the most sense. you want to predict, prescribe, and then persuade by engaging with this logical procession.

what purpose do they serve? (part 2.75)

refutations attack the flow (con't x2)

think about how your average 'mom judge' ranks people.

they might go, 'oh, _____ made a lot of sense and had the most convincing arguments! i'll rank them the highest.'

the 'flow' is not arbitrarily important, it's important because it cuts down the 'convincing factor' of your opponents. congressional debate is a game of persuasion, and making everyone else seem like they're not persuasive is going to help you secure ballots and win rounds. refutations allow you to do this directly.

what are the prereqs to refutations?

there are a couple of things you have to do before you start your refutations.

first, you need to write down what your opponents have said. this will be stressed later on, but it's crucial that, in order to accurately characterize what your opponents have said so you can cut it down later, you note every important argument on the other side.

second, you need to understand why a given argument is wrong. the logical inconsistencies, fallacies, tautologies, you name it. if there's a really good argument, you have to understand why it's flawed to point out its flaws. it REALLY helps to be politically aware or knowledgeable on the topic in order to do this, so keep up with the news - prior to round

Refutation Pre-reqs

- What 90% of the circuit does
 - Prep a CWDI point, prep unrelated refutation blocks.
 - What's the problem with this?
 - Your point and refutation should relate – your point should set up your refutation.
- What all of you will begin doing starting with the tournament tomorrow
 - When prepping, write down the main voting issues that will become points of contention.
 - Prep a round-defining point that directly complicates that voting issue in a certain way.
 - Read a lot about the topic. Leave links on your document.

For example: a debate on Saudi Arabia. What are the main voting issues/points of contention?

Do we lose leverage? Will US weapons shipments be replaced? Will this save lives?

Your speech could definitively prove that by stopping arms sales, we lose leverage in the region. By proving that, you've inherently set up a refutation to anyone who says that we don't.

iSn'T IEvErAgE a StoCK pOinT??

Refutation Pre-reqs Pt. 2

Continuing, you have a **constructive** negation argument that claims that stopping arms sales to Saudi Arabia we lose leverage over the kingdom.

- a) You can deliver that argument as it is if you speak early in the speech cycle.
- b) An affirmation speaker makes the argument that stopping arms sales will not affect U.S. leverage. You can use this and modify your original argument.

Ex. Representatives _____ & _____ in the negation tell us by stopping arms sales to the Kingdom we maintain leverage over the Kingdom while protecting human rights. Understand, that isn't true because [your logic -- where you refute the warrant]

Evidence

Impact/Summary

Could you do this in-round ? Yes. But you have to have an intimate understanding of the issue and be good at speaking.

what does an effective refutation look like?

now that you've both noted your opponent's argument down, and you have a compelling reason to prove why it's wrong, you need to follow these four SSSSteps.

- ❑ SIGNPOST your opponent's argument - i.e., 'Senator ____ on the affirmation contends that dogs are better than cats because dogs are cuter.'
- ❑ STATE your counterclaim - i.e., 'This is incorrect...'
- ❑ SUPPORT your stance - i.e., 'because empirics have shown that cats, on the scale of objective cuteness and anthropometry, are in fact cuter. turn to the University of Melbourne in August 2013 which explains that this is true because of feline facial structure being more favorable to the majority of humans.'
- ❑ SUMMARIZE why it matters - i.e., 'if cuteness is going to determine this argument, your vote is on the negation.'

what does an effective refutation look like? (part 2)

and this is what it looks like when i SIGNPOST, STATE, SUPPORT, AND SUMMARIZE.

Senator _____ on the affirmation contends that dogs are better than cats because dogs are cuter (SIGNPOST). This is incorrect (STATE) because empirics have shown that cats, on the scale of objective cuteness and anthropometry, are in fact cuter. turn to the University of Melbourne in August 2013 which explains that this is true because of feline facial structure being more favorable to the majority of humans (SUPPORT). if cuteness is going to determine this argument, your vote is on the negation (SUMMARIZE).

what does an effective refutation look like? (part 3)

let's break it down: the SIGNPOST

i begin by identifying the claim / argument that i'm about to refute, in the format:

Senators _____ and _____ tell us that _____.

you need to identify before you counter.

Representatives Gupta and Haldar both just told us that today's legislation helps upper income students the most

what does an effective refutation look like? (part 3)

let's break it down: the STATE

i then stake out my claim - in other words, i articulate that i disagree.

just STATE your basic position on their argument!

and I actually agree, but that's not inherently bad because student loan debt among the wealthy fuels primary care physician shortages because the wealthy are more likely to pursue medical school.

what does an effective refutation look like? (part 3)

let's break it down: the SUPPORT

after, i explain why i hold a disagreed position on their argument, utilizing both warrants and evidence to justify it.

this points out a characteristic of refutations: they're both offensive and defensive in nature.

The Albert Einstein College of Medicine explains in September of 2012 after surveying thousands of medical students before and after completing medical school found that 30% of students initially pursuing a career in primary care later switched their plans to higher paying professions in order to pay off their student debt. Here's the impact of that incentive: The Association of American Medical Colleges in April of 2019 now anticipates a shortage of anywhere from 14,800 to 49,300 primary care positions in the United states by 2030 which negatively impacts patient care.

what does an effective refutation look like? (part 3)

let's break it down: the SUMMARY

finally, i SUMMARIZE the refutation i've just made. keep in mind that refutations are inherently arguments in and of themselves - so it's important that i prove why this is important.

that's the point of the summary: to explain to the panel why everything you've just said holds some importance in a logical sequence.

Representative Lobo told us in the last session that today's legislation doesn't help communities of color enough. I say if that's true at the point of passage primary care physician shortages and clinic closures impact understaffed facilities in communities of color the most, which makes patient care a matter of paychecks.

what are the different strategies / styles to refutations?

there are a couple different ways to approach refutation arguments, often situationally.

we'll be covering the following 5:

- ❑ classic disadvantage refutation
- ❑ non-unique refutation
- ❑ delink refutation
- ❑ impact turn refutation
- ❑ political refutation

the names aren't really that important, but what matters are that these are just some strategies to keep in mind as you formulate responses.

what are the different strategies / styles to refutations?

before we move forward:

these different styles of refutations maintain the same 4-S structure.

crucially: while the SIGNPOST, STATE, and SUMMARIZE stay the same in all 5 strategies, the SUPPORT (which again is the content as to why your refutation is valid), is what changes in these examples.

i can't stress this enough: don't get caught up in the jargon, just remember the strategic utility behind all of these strategies. it's actually SUPER simple.

what are the different strategies / styles to refutations?

#1: classic disadvantage refutation:

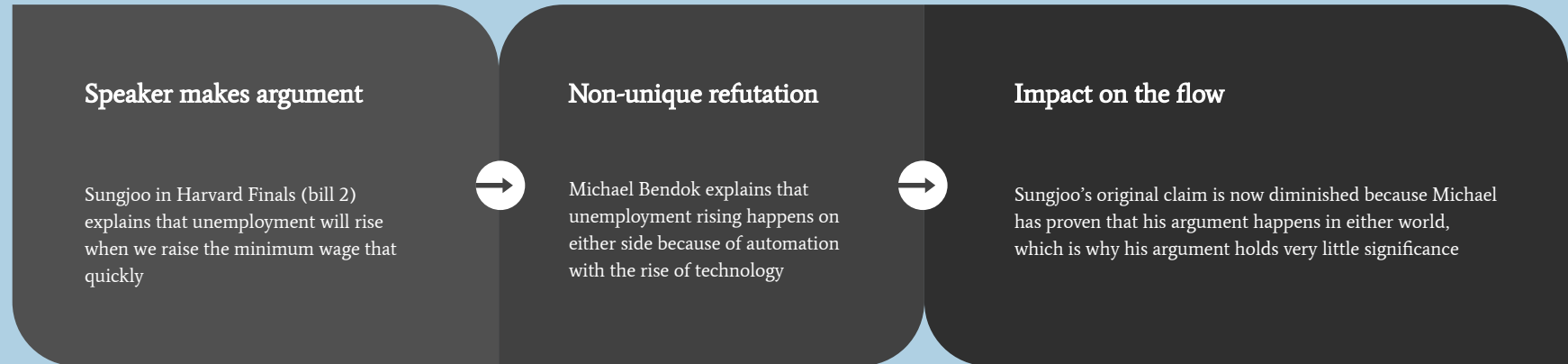
this, at its core, basically explains that the results of an advocacy are negative, which is why you should negate on weight.



what are the different strategies / styles to refutations?

#2: non-unique refutation:

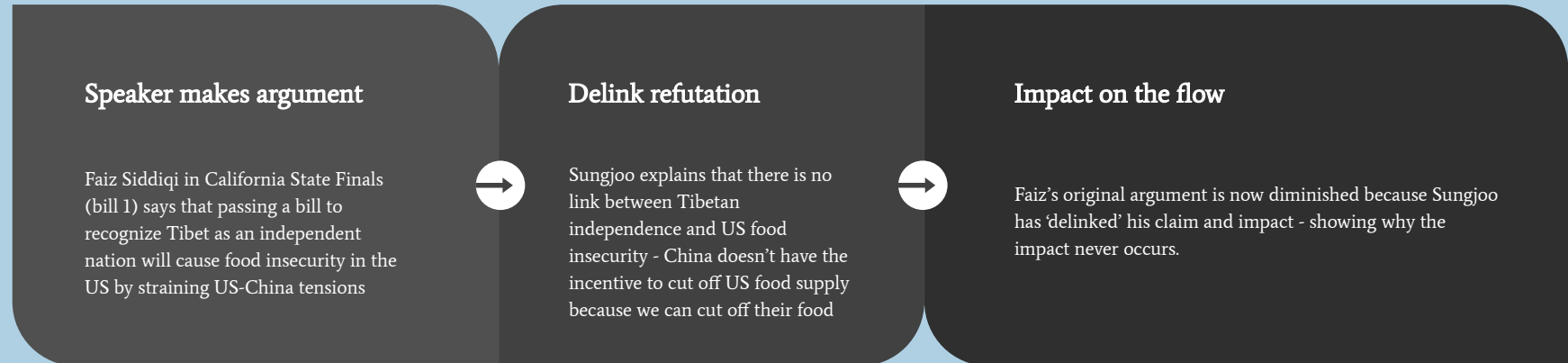
this, at its core, basically explains that the results of an argument don't have any effects that are different on the other side of the legislation.



what are the different strategies / styles to refutations?

#3: delink refutation:

this, at its core, basically explains that the results of an argument never occur, because there is no link between the speaker's claim and impact.



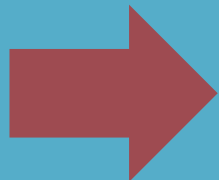
Advanced Refs: Link Turns

General Formula:

They say: A causes B, which **enables** C

You say: A causes B, which **prevents** C

End Saudi
Arm Sales

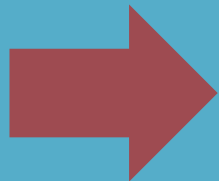


Decreases
Saudi
Aggression

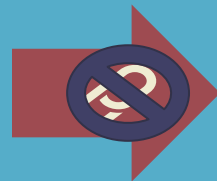


Saves Yemeni
Lives, b/c
Saudis can't
sustain war

End Saudi
Arm Sales



Decreases
Saudi
Aggression



Kills Yemenis,
b/c no Saudi
emboldens
Houthi rebels,
who are worse

what are the different strategies / styles to refutations?

#4: impact turn refutation:

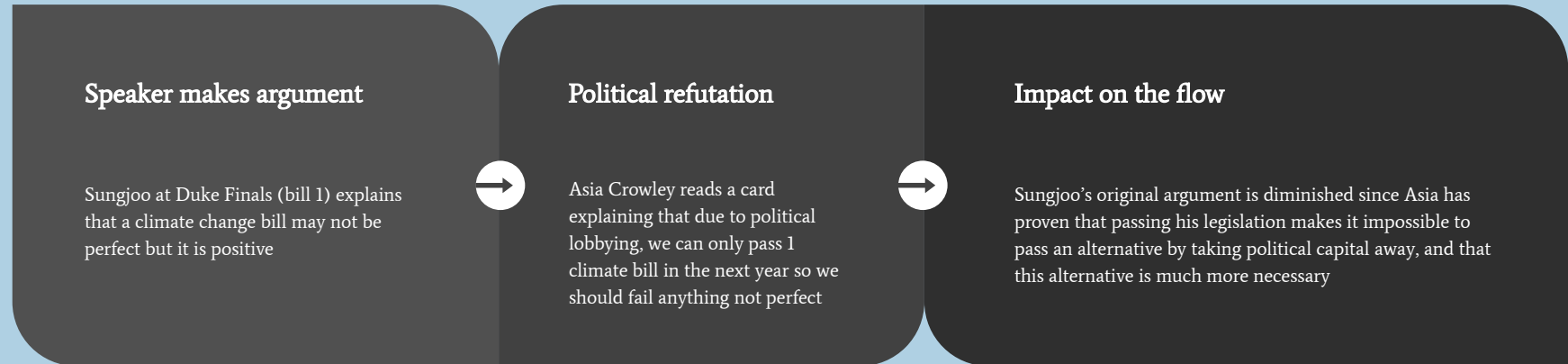
this, at its core, basically explains that the results of an argument are consistent, and the impact occurs, but the impact is actually bad and not good.



what are the different strategies / styles to refutations?

#5: political refutation:

this, at its core, basically explains that the results of an argument takes away political capital from another plan (non-T), which warrants failing.



Summary/Weighing: THE BIG THREE

- When comparing impacts, there are three major arguments that you should address:
 - **Timeframe** - how soon will the impact take place?
 - **Magnitude** - how big is the impact?
 - **Probability** - how likely is the impact?
 - **Scope**- how many people are affected?
- So for example, the impact of global human extinction is low **probability**, but a debater might argue that we should prioritize this impact because it is high **magnitude** (every human being) and the **timeframe** is immediate.
- Alternatively, their opponent could argue that state violence against immigrants is a more important impact than extinction because we should prioritize more probable, and therefore more realistic, impacts.

how do i perform one - let's practice! your turn:

we're debating a bill legalizing marijuana federally.

you are on the affirmation, and want to refute Senator Yoon's claim that legalizing marijuana will increase marijuana overdose deaths (on the negation).

use the 4 S's (SIGNPOST, STATE, SUPPORT, SUMMARIZE) to negate / refute his claim and prove the judges that you're superior!

how do i perform one - let's practice! your turn:

You're debating legislation on raising the minimum wage

You are on the affirmation and want to address Senator Yoon's negation argument that raising the minimum wage will hurt the economy because it will lead to job losses.

use the 4 S's (SIGNPOST, STATE, SUPPORT, SUMMARIZE) to negate / refute his claim and prove the judges that you're superior!

what are the different strategies / styles to refutations?

there are a couple different ways to introduce refutations in your speech.

we'll be covering the following 2:

- ❑ line-by-line introduction
- ❑ voters introduction

again, the names aren't really that important, but what matters are that these are just some strategies to keep in mind as you formulate responses.

what are the different strategies / styles to refutations?

before i go over how to introduce your formulated refutations in your speech, let me go over how much (the QUANTITY) of refutation you want to introduce.

a simple rule of thumb is that to get good ranks, at least SOME refutation needs to be introduced starting from the 2nd speech of the debate, and the amount should progressively increase as you go on. THIS IS NOT EXACT BY ANY MEANS - REFUTATION is utilized WHEN NECESSARY. But for pure beginners who struggle to put in enough ref, it serves as a good benchmark.

Speeches 2-4	About 30 seconds of your speech should be refutation material (early)
Speeches 5-6	About 1 minute of your speech should be refutation material (building)
Speeches 7-10	About 90 seconds of your speech should be refutation material (half-ref)
Speeches 11-12	Refutation should be used when necessary, however little or much (crystal)

what are the different strategies / styles to refutations?

line-by-line integration

this method is a way to introduce refutation material by going down 'line-by-line' of the other side. this is more common in earlier speeches.

here is a link to a speech doc with 'line-by-line' ref: <https://bit.ly/3hVHYyi>

this method goes speaker by speaker, argument by argument, and often literally line by line to deconstruct and introduce all refutation material that you might have.

what are the different strategies / styles to refutations?

voters integration

this method is a way to introduce refutation material by going down the important clashes of the round. this is more common in later speeches.

here is a link to a speech doc with ‘voters’ ref: <https://bit.ly/3hVHYyi>

this method goes issue by issue, where you recap the other side in its entirety by lumping issues together rather than going speaker by speaker, and conclusively tying up loose ends through your ref.

what are the different strategies / styles to refutations?

integration summary

while both are fundamentally similar styles, each serves different utility. for example, in a debate with a lot of rehash and only 3 key arguments on both sides, it would be wise to go with the 'voters' integration, since it allows you to lump refutations by argument.

however, in a debate where almost every one of your opponents is running a different argument, it would be wise to go with the 'line-by-line' integration, since you won't be able to respond to everything and thus you need to recap only the most important of their arguments by speaker. WHEN IN DOUBT, use this.